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"Rhetoric," "Logic," and "Poetics" in Burundi: Culture Patterning of Speech Behavior¹

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LIKE other universal categories of human behavior, speech is the object of diverse, complementary specializations. In the context of the ethnography of speaking, not only the language spoken but also the uses of speech may be assumed to have distinctive culture patterns. Ideally, total anthropological description of the pattern of a culture could well include its rules and uses of speech, their implementation and violation, and relevant sanctions, positive and negative. Conversely, when inquiry is focused on cultural patterns of speech behavior, the proper context is the whole culture pattern. Major intracultural variations in the uses of speech may be assumed to be systematically related to the constituents of culture patterns, including aspects of the social structure, cultural definitions of the situations of action, the cultural philosophy and value system, and their patterned interrelations.

Speech is so important and pervasive in any society that at least those with a reputation for wisdom or success are probably capable of stating the norms that govern the uses of speech. Moreover, enculturation includes instruction of the young not only in the mechanics of speaking but also in the patterns of speech behavior. Hence, virtually any adult and probably many young people are potential sources of relevant information, direct or inferential.

The traditional kingdom of Burundi² offers a particularly fortunate case study of culture patterning of speech behavior. Speech is explicitly recognized as an important instrument of social life; eloquence is one of the central values of the cultural world-view; and the way of life affords frequent opportunity for its exercise. Sensitivity to the variety and complexity of speech behavior is evident in a rich vocabulary for its description and evaluation and in a constant flow of speech about speech. Argument, debate, and negotiation, as well as elaborate literary forms are built into the organization of society as means of gaining one's ends, as social status symbols, and as skills enjoyable in themselves.

A highly secularized, sophisticated feudal kingdom with a population of approximately two million, traditional Burundi has well-defined criteria of rhetoric, logic, and poetics, and well-developed ideas about their uses and interrelations. The norms governing the uses of speech are explicitly differentiated according to caste, sex, and age, so that the relations of speech behavior to social structure are easily grasped by observers. Formalization and stylization of speech situations are extensive and elaborate, suggesting ways in which the uses of language are conditioned by culturally distinctive conceptions of situational appropriateness. Esthetic criteria are well developed and pervasive in their range of relevance. Explicit concern with the values of truth and falsity and their situa-

tional relativism leads from the concepts governing the uses of speech to the premises of the cultural world-view and value system.

Adoption of the terms, "rhetoric," "logic," and "poetics" from western culture is necessarily tentative and obviously entails the risk of culture-bound distortion. Conventional denotative meanings will be used, i.e., "rhetoric" will designate the norms and techniques of persuasion, as well as criteria of styles of delivery in public speaking; "logic" will refer to the rules and uses of evidence and inference; and "poetics" will refer to the esthetic criteria that govern discourse. The referents of these terms are neither precise nor unambiguous in their native cultural habitat. "Poetics" overlaps with "rhetoric" insofar as public address and persuasion are governed by esthetic rules; the line between rhetoric and sophistry is so fine that it not infrequently disappears when persuasion is contrasted with the strict rules of logic and the ideals of literal, descriptive truth. Admittedly of limited utility, the terms "rhetoric," "logic," and "poetics" nevertheless call attention to a significant and sizeable but often neglected body of data relative to culture patterns of speech behavior. They are also potentially useful for cross-cultural comparisons.

The primary intention of this paper is an exploration of concepts and categories that may be useful for constructing cultural patterns of speech behavior, but a number of methodological points merit attention. Many of the components of Rundi patterns for the uses of speech will appear very familiar to western observers. Some of the key terms and concepts have much the same referential meanings as their English translations. However, contextual meanings—meanings that arise out of the relationships among the constituent elements of discourse—vary with specific cultural sets of assumptions and values. The allocation of intellectual resources in Burundi is controlled by a hierarchy of values far removed from that of the western view or scientific approach to discourse, though very close to that of other African cultures and many Mediterranean societies. Practical and esthetic values take precedence over logical criteria in all but a few classes of communication situation. A well-brought-up Murundi would suffer agonies of shame in the presence of the naked truth and would hasten to provide the esthetic coverings called for by the cultural value system. Reliance upon appeals to the emotions as the chief technique of rhetoric is taken for granted as right and natural and indeed the whole ground of its utility. There are no reservations about the desirability of flattery, untruths, taking advantage of weakness of character or profiting from others' misfortune. Whatever works is good, and esthetic-emotive values are higher in the hierarchy than moral or logical principles in speech and other behavior. The implications for field work of the functions of the cultural world-view and value system in determining the context of speech behavior will be discussed in the conclusion.

SOCIAL STRUCTURAL DEFINITIONS OF SPEECH SITUATIONS

Background: Hierarchical Order in the Universe and Society

The importance of speech to survival and success as well as the primacy of esthetic-emotive values in speech behavior follow directly from Rundi causal theory. In the universe at large and in society, personal power is the sole or chief

causal force; it is conceived as directed by the actor's free choice; choice is viewed as dependent on emotional dispositions, assumed to be unstable and changeable. There is a steady diminution of power, hence of freedom of self-determination, and proportionally an increase in subjection to the whim and will of superiors in the hierarchy, from the high god (*Imana*), to the king (*mwami*), the princes (*bagamwa*), the nobles (*abafasoni*), the herders (*Batutsi*), the farmer-peasant caste (*bahutu*), to the lowborn pariahs (*Batwa*).

In a voluntaristic-emotive universe, no event is predictable, but what actually happens depends on the good pleasure of the determining superior power. Since emotion is the spring of action and since emotion is much affected by esthetic factors, manipulation of emotions by esthetic devices is the principal business of speech behavior. To procure a gift and protection from a superior, to obtain a favorable judgment in a court case, to defend oneself against calumny or accusations of wrongdoing, to oust a rival—in short, to survive and to succeed—is everybody's concern. The particularities of esthetic criteria vary, chiefly in degree or rigor of application, with subject matter, situation, and social roles, but the primacy of esthetic-emotive values gives the impression that there is more poetry than truth in the flow of discourse.

Speech Training

Socialization patterns reveal the main lines of social role differentiation as relative to caste, age, and sex. *Ubukuru*, seniority or superiority, is the guiding principle of all behavior: caste order is known; the older are superior to the younger; men to women. The ideal of good breeding and aristocracy, *imfura*, includes "speaking well" as one of its principal elements. From about the tenth year, boys in the upper social strata are given formal speech training. The "curriculum" includes composition of impromptu speeches appropriate in relations with superiors in age or status; formulas for petitioning a superior for a gift; composition of *amazina*, praise-poems; quick-witted, self-defensive rhetoric intended to deflect an accusation or the anger of a superior. Correct formulas for addressing social inferiors, for funeral orations, for rendering judgment in a dispute, or for serving as an intermediary between an inferior petitioner and one's feudal superior are learned in the course of time as, with increasing age and maturity, each type of activity becomes appropriate. Training includes mastery of a suitable, elegant vocabulary, of tone of voice and its modulation, of graceful gestures with hand and spear, of general posture and appropriate bodily displacements, of control of eye-contacts, especially with inferiors, and above all, of speedy summoning of appropriate and effective verbal response in the dynamics of interpersonal relations.

Girls in the upper castes are also carefully trained, but to artful silence and evasiveness and to careful listening that will enable them to repeat nearly verbatim what has been said by visitors or neighbors. Faithful wives and daughters, servants, and feudal dependents are expected to recount to the men of the family anything they have heard that might be construed as inimical to husband, father, or brother, or as helpful in combatting a real or potential enemy of the family. Public speaking is unseemly for women, the proper pattern of the *imfura*

female being shyness and delicacy. However, maturity brings with it the development of highly effective bargaining and negotiating skills for use behind the scenes. There are many women who in fact make the decisions presented publicly by their husbands, or who become politically or economically powerful through skillful, if discreet and private, use of rhetoric. Except at the extreme top and bottom of the social scale, each individual learns verbal formulas and styles appropriate to a variety of roles, some those of a social superior, some those of an inferior.

Forms of Petition

Petitioning for gifts or favors is one of the most frequent situations of interpersonal communication. It is, then, not surprising that it is highly stylized. When a man asks for cattle or a bride, or a wife or son asks the head of the household for permission to smoke or drink beer or to pay a visit to a neighbor or relative, a physical position of submission is assumed by the petitioner. Kneeling in the presence of the superior is usual if the matter is intrafamilial. In the formal business of requesting cattle or a bride, the petitioner assumes a formal stance, often standing during delivery of the formal request. His speech has probably been carefully composed in advance. To follow the general formula, one refers to the gift one has brought, usually several pots of banana beer; one expresses love, admiration, and respect for the excellent qualities, real, imagined, and hoped-for, of the superior; one expresses the hope that the affection is reciprocated; one again refers to the gift, this time as a token of affection; one promises further gifts in the future; one states one's wish; one closes with a repetition of the praise of the superior and an expression of hope that the wish will be granted. Seeking cattle or a wife entails a series of visits, each formal, but graded so that negotiations proceed efficiently. Cues to refuse requests are sometimes delayed, superiors thereby gaining pots of beer or services without compensating the petitioners.

Choice of vocabulary and of gestures and other paralinguistic elements tends towards the ideal set by the aristocratic superior, but realization of the ideal varies, quite expectably, with the characteristics of the petitioner. Humble peasant women are not infrequently capable of a very good approximation to the ideal, the speech flowing gracefully and smoothly, the gestures fitting the words, the compliments framed in poetic figures of speech. On the other hand, some members of upper caste patrilineages lack the wit or the character to learn their speech manners, and are privately or even publicly mocked for behaving like peasants. For appropriate speech behavior for peasants in intercaste relations is that of an inferior; their words are haltingly delivered or run on uncontrolled, their voices are loud, their gestures wild, their figures of speech ungainly, their emotions freely displayed, their words and sentences clumsy.

Formulas for Visiting, Formal and Informal

The notion of idle talk has little place in Rundi conceptions of verbal behavior. So too, the notion of a social call without a purpose is not entertained,

except in rare instances. Self-interest is assumed natural and universal; purposive behavior, especially speech behavior, is its assumed natural complement. Visiting is subject to a variety of formulas which must be learned. A distinction may be made between formal and informal visiting. Formal visits include those made to a feudal superior to request new favors, to give formal thanks for favors received, to remind him of one's continuing loyalty, to improve the occasion by listening to whatever gossip may be available. Distinguished neighbors expect to be waited upon by their inferiors and occasionally confer upon their inferiors the honor of a visit. In either case, it is necessary to send at least one pot of beer in advance, both to announce one's intention to visit and also so that the host or hostess will be sure to "have something to offer." Hospitality, understood as offering drink and food, is a key value in social life. Visiting, even when formal, need not preclude some quiet talk of a political nature, calumny or lesser gossip, plans for cooperation in effecting the downfall of some common enemy, probing for cues as to possible gifts, and other everyday concerns of a very politically alert people.

Family visits for various occasions involve different sets of proper formulas for verbal and other behavior. The heaviest constraints of formality govern visits between a father and a married daughter, separated by a nearly total avoidance taboo. In the event of important business to be transacted, e.g., if the daughter wishes to break up her marriage and hence impose upon the father the necessity to receive her again in his household and to return the bride-price, intermediaries must be used. A somewhat less rigid avoidance relation obtains between mother-in-law and son-in-law. He is obliged to pay visits of respect, but he is forbidden to seek her out at her hearth; joking and levity are proscribed; each addresses the other as *mufasoni*, noble, irrespective of actual caste. Nephews and nieces visiting a paternal aunt are bound by a strict respect pattern, tempered by the fact that the home of the paternal aunt is a quasi-sacred sanctuary from an angry father or paternal uncle. Diminishing degrees of formality may be traced through the kinship system to the open, joking relations between cross-cousins and the spouses of cross-cousins and between grandchildren and grandparents. These call for rough sexual joking. Occasionally, young people take umbrage at the sexual jokes of older relatives, but there is open, strong disapproval of so inappropriate a response. More in keeping with custom is a young grandson's teasing his grandmother by telling her he will not go to bed with her because she is wrinkled and ugly, to which a suitable response would be an offer of references of excellence of performance based on long experience.

Family attendance at funerals is expected even of those residing some distance away, to comfort the bereaved ones and to take over the household and other chores which they are too grief-stricken to perform, but also to keep an eye on the execution of the last will and testament if a head of a household is being mourned. After the burial, there are formal orations and pledges of help, the trotting out of calves or cattle in silent acknowledgment that debts and obligations incurred by the dead man will be honored by his heirs. Quarreling among the heirs is so common as to be almost part of the prescribed behavior. The "mani-

fest content" of disputes is often some trivial goods not specified in the will. To quote one Murundi, "Brothers will fight almost to the death over a basket of beans." The outcome is far from trivial: quarrels test the power of the father's heir and set up a pecking order among siblings. Departures from the family homestead may result.

Quarreling is also a semiformalized part of another prescribed family affair, the wedding. Quarrels between representatives of the two families start as a symbolic abduction struggle. With the help of many pots of beer, the symbolic fight not infrequently becomes quarreling in earnest. However, in these as in other situations where quarreling is virtually inevitable, some members of the family will probably have kept sober so as to act as sergeants-at-arms and prevent matters from getting too far out of hand.

Relatives and neighbors are expected to make a formal call upon anyone who has just been through a ritual cleansing ceremony, e.g. a woman after the birth of twins. The visit signifies that they can now "ask for fire from that house," the symbol that normal and friendly social relations may safely be resumed.

A limited amount of informal dropping-in on neighbors occurs, more often than not the visitor being led to his destination by the news that there is a supply of beer available. Gossip flows freely in proportion to the flow of beer, sometimes too freely. As in most other cultures, drinking parties tend to end in fighting.

Occasionally, the form of a neighborly or friendly social call is given to a visit motivated by a mission frequently assumed on behalf of friends or relatives, viz., looking over a family into which the friend's or relative's son or daughter may marry. Semiformal in pattern, such missions bear all the signs of being to some purpose, and each party knows at what discount to take the other's questions and assertions.

A long list of amenities, conventions, and rules are part of the Barundi's pattern of polite interpersonal relations and conversation. In the old days, age-mates greeted each other in a lengthy ceremony of sung greetings, embraces, and stylized gestures; children knelt before parents or grandparents to pay respect and to receive blessings; feudal inferiors greeting a superior proceeded through the numerous steps of an elaborate assurance of affection and respect that involved verbal formulas accompanied by touching the superior with both hands literally from head to foot.

Rules of Precedence and Good Speech Manners

The order in which individuals speak in a group is strictly determined by seniority of rank. If the eldest present is lower in social rank than some other individual, age gives way before social status. Thus, a nephew may be older than his uncle but the uncle is of higher rank and will speak before him. A prince or chief may be younger than others present but speaks first by virtue of his higher rank. There are no recorded instances of confusion or conflict in the matter of determining order of precedence, even in very large groups.

In public, the rule for servants, females, and other inferiors is to speak when

spoken to but otherwise to maintain silence. Nevertheless, the pattern is so arranged that younger or socially inferior persons are in due course able to express their views. Thus, the senior person will speak first; the next in order of rank opens his speech with a statement to the effect, "Yes, I agree with the previous speaker, he is correct, he is older and knows best, etc." Then, depending on circumstances and issues, the second speaker will by degrees or at once express his own views, and these may well be diametrically opposed to those previously expressed. No umbrage is taken, the required formula of acknowledgment of the superior having been used. If the *umukuru*, senior person, is truly very aged and weak, his son may speak first, explaining his departure from the rules at the outset: "My father is old, his memory is not good, he wishes me to speak for him," or some other appropriate excuse is given. It is not unusual for the formal order of precedence to be abandoned in the latter part of a protracted discussion, and for loud voices to be heard even among upper-class individuals.

Caste stereotypes represent those in the upper strata of society as never raising their voices or allowing anger or other emotions to show. It is said that the Batutsi herders prefer to bear a grudge silently and to take revenge when opportunity permits, even if it comes twenty years after the affront has been suffered. This applies to dealings with individuals of their own class. Communication with inferiors involves a different approach that includes a kind of stylized "reverse signaling." If an underling quietly accepts an order, there is a good chance that he is showing respect but has no intention of carrying out the order. On the other hand, if he gets his resentments out of his system by shouting protest and refusal and by drawing his superior into a noisy quarrel, he is almost certain at the end to do as he has been told.

It is assumed that the peasants express their emotions and opinions freely, do not bear grudges, and are generally warmer, more open and forthright, and friendlier than herders. Generally, the Batutsi herders live up to their reputation for dignity in public speaking situations. They are expert in applying as a very effective rhetorical technique the rule that silence is golden. Good rhetoricians, they appreciate the utility of refraining from comment or reply or rejoinder. The perfect, glacial silence of a Murundi who has chosen not to speak has to be experienced to be appreciated. To all appearances, the silence can be maintained indefinitely and in the face of every known technique of provocation. In family conclave or political caucus, silence on the part of the ranking person present effectively negates the proceedings. It is understood by all attending as total disapproval. Also, it directly blocks further discussion: application of the principle of seniority is such that a superior's silence effectively silences all his social inferiors. At the very top of the social hierarchy, all the skills and patterns of refined behavior are expectably fully controlled but they are modified by the value of princely magnanimity and benevolence.

Respect Patterns and Role Relativism

An intelligent man must measure the character of his interlocutor and select style and content for his speech accordingly. It would be an unforgivable

blunder for a peasant-farmer, no matter how wealthy or able, to produce a truly elegant, eloquent, rapid-fire defense before a herder or other superior. However, the same peasant who stammers or shouts or forces a smile from a superior by making a rhetorical fool of himself when his adversary is a prince or herder will, with a change in the situation involving his superiors, or as a judge in a local or family affair, in a council, or in making a funeral oration, show himself an able speaker, a dignified man who speaks as slowly and as intelligently as ever a high-born herder could. The accent will be different; the figures of speech will more likely be drawn from agriculture than from herding and only in the rare instance reflect knowledge of courtly life; the gestures of the muscular arms and heavy-set body and the facial expressions will not be like those of the long-limbed, slim-boned, narrow-headed "Hamitic" Batutsi herders, but they will not lack studied grace and dignity.

If in his role as rhetorician, the fortunate peasant is skillful and not at all the humble, mumbling fool he plays before his caste superiors, he is at least in control. Or, if he cannot make a fine speech, he has a legitimate excuse in his inherited caste inferiority. There are high-born men who speak badly, either because nature failed to endow them with the intelligence and innate verbal ability and grace assumed to be the biological inheritance of the herders or because drink, disease, or private disaster have destroyed their character. Failure to speak clearly and well, clumsy and wild gestures and allowing emotions to show, earn such unfortunates the epithet, *muhutu*, peasant, whose socially stereotyped speech pattern they employ for want of the power to do better.

In Kirundi, as in French and other languages, the second person singular is the familiar, the second person plural is the respect form. In addressing a superior, the plural must be used. Thus, to thank an inferior, one may say *urakoze*, but to thank a superior, it must be *murakoze*. The nonverbal signs of respect are numerous. In effect, they consist of the whole set of defining characteristics of social inferiority. The inferior walks behind the superior, drinks and eats after the superior has begun or only after he has finished. If the superior is of princely rank, nobody may be present during mealtimes, the taster remaining but with his back to his master. The inferior talks only after the superior has spoken. He inclines his head in respect, and the body, too, must signal humility, obedience, and respect.

A highly formal respect situation, once official business is completed, may on the spot abruptly change into easy, informal discussion. The redefinition of the situation may be presumed to follow some sign from the superior, probably a change from the formal stance prescribed for official business to "at-ease." In response, the social inferior drops the plural form of address, and the bodily stance and use of voice are transformed from "humble respect" to "relaxed." Particularly if the subject of discussion is cattle, the Barundi's favorite subject for bull-sessions, informality prevails. Voices rise higher as differences of opinion are defined and defended, the expression of various emotions being permitted and even expected for this topic. The debating pair may easily be constituted of a high-born prince and low-born cowherd in his employ, but once the signal

for informal discussion has been given, the respect pattern becomes not merely irrelevant but improper. However, a judicious inferior will not allow himself the liberty of too enthusiastic disagreement despite the permissiveness, nor overlook any cues to future opportunities for requesting a gift or otherwise assuring or improving his position.

Formulas of Politeness

A full inventory of amenities and conventions would properly include the numerous minor rules governing speech. There are few word taboos. It is forbidden to tell what one has eaten for dinner, or to mention the name of a dead person in the presence of relatives, and euphemisms are in order when referring to excretion. Violations of the rules are breaches of good taste, and verbal bad manners are likely to be condemned by a graceful gesture and the expression, *n'ishano*, "how shocking!" The Rundi technique for avoiding an unwanted visitor is familiar: a child or servant is sent to announce that nobody is home. It is perfectly proper for a servant or child to enter a room where company is being entertained and to whisper some message to the host or hostess. It is understood that something has gone wrong or that another visitor has arrived. (An outside observer trained to a different and negative evaluation of whispering in company, has to make an adjustment to local mores—perhaps more of a strain than learning the meaning of some totally new element.) As in other communities, there are polite formulas for terminating a visit. Men usually offer thanks for hospitality and leave. Women will offer their excuses "I must go home now, there is nobody watching the house," or "I must go home now, or my husband will beat me." Rundi women may not properly leave their homes without permission from their husbands, so that reference to the common and socially-accepted practice of wife-beating means simply that permission to leave the house had not been requested. It is as likely to be offered as an excuse by a peasant woman as by a lady so distinguished for her gentility that she has been selected as governess in a princely residence. (Again, an outside observer may have to overcome a certain "culture shock" the first few times the threat of a beating is daintily offered in farewell.)

In sum, the patterning of speech behavior in Burundi in relation to social structure involves rules governing the specific relationships among those present in a speech situation according to caste, age and sex, kinship, friendship, or political-economic ties. Distinctions are made according to the social roles of those present; the degree of formality, publicity or privacy; and the objectives of the speech situation. Together, social role and situational prescriptions determine the order of precedence of speakers, relevant conventions of politeness, appropriate formulas and styles of speech, and topics of discussion. Socialization and sanctions are also determined by the social role-situational complexes within which discourse occurs. A full description of the social patterning of speech behavior would require all the details of social-role and situational variables and their interrelationships. In principle, these can be generalized and applied to the study of social patterns of speech behavior of other cultures.

UBGENGE: THE ALLOCATION OF INTELLECTUAL RESOURCES

Ethnoepistemological Values

The conceptual context of the uses of intellectual resources, among which speech ranks high in many societies, involves examination of the cultural world-view and value system. An understanding of the patterning of the content and style of speech in Burundi depends in part upon awareness of the cultural conceptions of truth, falsehood, and fiction and of their value priorities and interrelations. The key concept for appreciating the norms and values associated with the uses of language is *ubgence*, "successful cleverness." *Ubgence* chiefly applies to intellectual-verbal management of significant life-situations. Situational adaptability is a permanent condition of action. Hence, the specific manifestations of *ubgence* are numerous and diverse. The cleverness of a rogue; the industriousness of a virtuous man whose overload gives him a cow as a reward for virtue; the skill of a good psychologist-rhetorician in persuading a generous, impulsive—or thoroughly inebriated—superior to give him a cow although he had done nothing to earn it; the skill of a medical curer; the success of a practical joker who has victimized some simple-minded peasant or feeble-minded boy; the wise and just judgments of the *abashingantake*, the "elders," in courts and councils; and the technological accomplishments of Europeans are all equally good examples of *ubgence*—for they all succeed in bringing something good to their designers. In effect, success is beautiful and the beautiful is likely to succeed. Factual accounts, fables and legends of successful cleverness evoke strong, positive, esthetic appreciation.

In the Rundi vocabulary, the distinctions made between fact and fiction, truth and falsehood, are not distinguishable from those of western culture. Their hierarchical order and situational relativity, however, depend on Rundi interpretations of the values of survival, esthetics, and satisfaction of desire. Distinctions are made between literal truth and fact, outright lies, errors, being misled or ill-informed, offering a hypothesis without sufficient prior knowledge, foolishly offering an explanation despite ignorance in order to seem knowledgeable, and formulating a hypothesis or making a judgment on the basis of satisfactory evidence. Context distinguishes shades of meaning of *kuvuga*, to speak; *kumva*, to hear, to understand, to conceive of; and *kumenya*, to know, to observe, to perceive.

Oriented more to persons and personalities than to abstract principles, the Barundi tend to use shades of difference or reliability in substantives designating types of persons. Labeling a man a liar does not result from his tendency to falsify factual statements, but rather denotes breaking promises to give a gift or do a favor. Of especial emotional impact is the conception of the calumniator who reports evil of a man, with or without good grounds.

The cultural requirement of fine rhetorical style applies to all public speaking. Methods and techniques vary with objective. Logic is the correct method for the *umushingantake*, whose goal is to arrive at a sound judgment, as a judge presiding in a formal court of law or informally adjudicating a family dispute,

offering counsel at the behest of a political superior, or decision-making and problem-solving in the conduct of life's serious business. Rhetoric is the natural and acceptable resort of self-interested individuals, whether they are seeking to win a law suit or to procure a gift or protection from a superior or to satisfy a desire or fulfill a need, the usual techniques including evasions, falsehoods, flattery and other emotional appeals.

Adults of both sexes in the various castes and age-groups learn both sets of criteria and the situations in which they are applicable. A well-developed ethno-psychology is as pervasive through all types of speech situation as is the esthetic, the emotive and esthetic being twin necessities. The relative frequencies of logic-oriented and rhetoric-oriented speech situations and their specific objectives depend on age and position in the social structure. The higher a man is placed, the less often must he defend himself, for the fewer are his superiors. On the other hand, they are more likely to be intelligent and powerful and therefore dangerous, and defenses against numerous clever inferiors have to be mounted with increasing frequency.

Ubushingantahe: Logical and Rhetorical Ideal Values

The highest ideal of public speaking is associated with the role of *umush-ingantahe*. A good judge is intelligent, in complete command of the arts of logic, a fine speaker—i.e., he speaks slowly and with dignity, in well-chosen words and figures of speech; he is attentive to all that is said; and he is an able analyst of logic and of the vagaries of the human psyche. Initiation as *umush-ingantahe* comes late—usually, not before forty-five—and is reserved for men of means who can pay for the costly initiation party and who have demonstrated ability, usually in a prolonged apprenticeship of attendance at cases conducted by good judges. The qualifications stipulated for judges are explained as indispensable to the resolution of conflicts. For it is apparent that the self-interest and emotional involvements of disputants and witnesses will lead them to falsify evidence, to exaggerate accounts of damage or claims, and even to perjure themselves, and testimony is likely to be contradictory. All human relationships involve matching wits, and in law cases and councils, the stakes are sometimes as high as a man's life or property.

Principles for the analysis of testimony are readily verbalized by court judges. They are closely analogous to the principles in use in the western world. Contradictory statements cannot both be true, so a choice must be made; the discovery of the truth depends upon evidence; in its evaluation, the credibility of the witnesses has to be weighed; eye-witness testimony is the most reliable. So insistent is the demand for direct evidence that where it is possible and relevant, a judge may adjourn court and go in person to verify statements, e.g., respecting the location of a boundary marker between properties. Usually, however, such direct examination is not possible. To get at the truth, judges will subject principals and witnesses to repeated questioning if contradictory testimony has been given. After listening, sifting and winnowing to come to a conclusion as to the actual facts, the judge will probably recall each one who has testified, con-

front him with his own contradictions or the heavy weight of probability against him, and usually contrive to get an admission of the true state of affairs.

The use of psychological observation and principles is part of the judge's apparatus, an adjunct to logical analysis and fact-finding. Rules for detecting lies, exaggerations, and other departures from fact, and for spotting subtle cues to distinguish guilty from innocent nervousness or eloquence, are easily verbalized by experienced elders. In addition, the judges have mastery over appropriate rhetorical techniques for wearing down stubborn witnesses, quieting overexcited ones, browbeating by silence or scorn, and various other devices that experience has shown will give the judge, hence the truth, the upper hand. There is no tolerance for the technique of "strategic obfuscation" used by many Barundi to the despair of trial lawyers and judges during European trusteeship government, viz. calculated inconsistencies in accounts of events directed (often with great success) to so obscuring the truth that no case could be made.

In dealing with domestic disputes, judges are first concerned with psychological factors and proceed to fact-finding only if it is relevant. For example, a judge must discover from the spoken words and the general demeanor of a couple demanding a divorce whether in truth they wish to save face by having the court order them back together again or whether a divorce is in keeping with their wishes and best interests. In settling quarrels between father and son, a judge has a doubly difficult task. Custom has it that the elder is never wrong. The judge must discover what really happened. If in fact the father is at fault, he must find a way to tell him so and to impose a suitable penalty without openly stating he is in the wrong.

Determination of appropriate principles and techniques for each case is in effect part of the *ubenge*, the cleverness of a judge or the wisdom of any mature person in the conduct of life's business. Each one must make judgments—to decide whether a wife should be kept or be sent back to her father and the bride-price refunded; to choose as heir from among sons the one who will be best able to carry on the responsibility of head of the family; to select spouses for sons and daughters; to choose or dismiss feudal inferiors, or to choose or to abandon a feudal superior. Truth, as fact tied into a web of sound logical organization, is indispensable.

The Survival Value of Discretion and Falsehood

Though truth is necessary for judgment, it is not well adapted to survival or practical success. The Barundi make no bones about this: the proverb is often quoted, "The man who tells no lies cannot feed his children." Another proverb warning against truth reveals further the awareness of the Barundi that speech is not simply an instrument of social life but is often a weapon: "Truth is good, but not all that is true is good to say." Truth is not valuable in itself but is relative to other values. It is positively required when judgment is needed, positively dangerous when a person wishes to maintain or better his position or when he must defend himself.

The need for discretion, a halfway house between literal truth and bald lie,

is understood as either not speaking at all about delicate matters or as refurbishing facts so that they wear an innocent face. Appropriate to a wide variety of situations in life, the specific character of discretion depends on specific situations and actors. In political matters (probably the chief concern of Burundi at every level of the society) discretion is necessary as a self-defensive measure. Information about the misbehavior or the faults of a political superior is best concealed, at least until such time as he has lost status and is thereby deprived of power to harm. Loyalty to a superior is defined largely in terms of what is said about him; if one spreads praises abroad—and *amazina*, "singing the praises," of a superior is one of the formalized means of demonstrating loyalty—then one may hope for reward; if one speaks ill of a superior, the disloyalty will bring down heavy punishment on the guilty one if it reaches the superior's ears.

Between socio-political "equals," that is, those seeking favor with the same political superior, calumny is the chief weapon, discretion the best shield. Given the importance and quantity of verbal report in gossip and in calculated calumny and praise that may reach the ears of the superior, safety absolutely requires the concealment of faults and the devising of means to counteract calumny, whether or not it has a basis in fact. No one is so high or low in the social scale, no one so secure in the affections of a superior, as to be able to afford the luxury of telling the unvarnished truth. Few if any individuals are so lacking in intelligence and in an esthetic sense of graceful, appropriate discourse as to blurt out truths without restraint or to reply truthfully to questions from the curious. In relations between husband and wife and in family relations generally, verbal discretion is a serious matter. A lazy wife or a sterile one may or may not be sent back home; a disloyal woman, one who speaks ill of her husband, is assured severe punishment and rejection. A disobedient son may be tolerated and even procure his share of the inheritance, but a disloyal one may be disinherited.

In lesser matters than life and property and position, discretion still has its place. One may discuss with close friends and neighbors the problems created by a spouse who is a bit slow-witted, but not broadcast the fact far and wide. If one suspects that a neighbor is a witch, one refrains from mentioning it in his presence. There is no point in accusing him, it is said, for he will say, "Death is not afraid to come, whether you speak of it or not." Or, "Whom have I killed? Have you caught me at it?" There are, then, some truths not to be spoken aloud to anyone; some to a faithful spouse but nobody else; some to close relatives or neighbors. Only rarely is any statement so innocent that it is not necessary to consider the possibility that it will bring trouble.

There is a premium, practical and esthetic, upon rapid, graceful, and more-than-plausible falsehood. Especially if anyone is directly accused of wrongdoing, on-the-spot composition of an effective defense is necessary. In general, a man is safer when he thinks quickly and lies, mixing the right amount of flattery for his superior with the other ingredients of his discourse, than when he tells the truth, good though the truth may be in some situations. These seems no anxiety, where lies are told or false accusations made, as to the possible consequences of subsequent discovery of the facts. If one survives the critical mo-

ment, one may find a way to deal with an ungainly or inconvenient truth if and when it reappears. Escape to another part of the country; a generous gift to the right person; a change in mood of the feudal protector or accuser; in fact, anything may happen. The fight for time entailed in on-the-spot inventions of defense is associated with an optimistic interpretation of the uncertainty of the future.

A cool head counts for more than a high I.Q. in realizing the practical-esthetic-emotive values of effective speech. Everyone knows the rules: everyone plays the game of matching wits through verbal parry and thrust. Differences of individual skills, the likelihood of fortuitous circumstance, and the inherent instability of emotions make it certain that there will be few dull moments. Uncertainty of the outcomes of verbal manipulations of one's affairs is built into the system and is part of the game, enjoyed when the outcome is favorable, lamented when it is not.

An Illustration of Ubenge in Action

A full account of rhetorical styles and techniques and of situations in which they are to be used would be necessary to a full description of this aspect of speech behavior. A single illustration must suffice here to indicate the way in which Rundi values, esthetic and practical, operate in behavior. It is contemporary in theme, traditional in form, enjoyed equally for its success and elegance of design. For what it may be worth, it was sworn to as having actually occurred. A Murundi chief, who will remain nameless, of course, was very rude to a young Murundi agricultural officer. Instead of doing as he was told, viz., collecting a labor force to start a coffee plantation, the chief went off to drink with one of his favorite tenants. Discovered, the chief was roundly scolded by the agricultural officer and assured that a report would be made to the higher authorities, i.e., the Belgian senior agricultural officer of the region. In due course, the summons came. The chief ordered his wife to fill three huge baskets with food and dressed in his finest robes. With his porters carrying the baskets, he proceeded to the office of the Belgian administrator. He was accused of refusing to provide workers to plant coffee, of rudeness as well as disobedience to the junior officer present, of permitting his cattle to browse on the plot designated for the coffee plantation. On hearing the accusation, the chief looked very grieved and surprised. "Sir," he said, with all the respect and elegance his education had provided, "I have never seen this person. Since he knows my lands, perhaps he is the one about whom my tenants complained a few weeks back as demanding beer and getting drunk and disorderly." He waited a moment for that to take effect, counting on the suspicion of weakness for beer and tendency to false report to be transferred to the junior officer, then went on, "I am here because I have heard that you are suffering from famine. Here are the few humble baskets of food I could assemble in haste, but do not fear, there are many more on the way. I wish you all health." Of course, the administrator was furious with his junior officer and very favorably impressed by the chief. The officer was punished, the

chief courteously released. On the way home he passed a church. Being a good Christian, he stopped to pray. Addressing himself to God, he confessed his false accusation of the young agricultural officer, a fellow-Murundi, and a fellow-Christian. He explained to the Lord that he knew he had sinned, but he begged forgiveness: "O God, surely you will pardon me; since you did not save me, I had to save myself."

LITERARY FORM AND LITERAL TRUTH

The Esthetic Hierarchy of Speech Forms

Practicality, esthetic values, and literal truth in different proportions characterize most Rundi discourse that satisfies cultural criteria for speech. Descriptive precision and literal description are relevant not only in the fact-finding situation of judgment but also in discussion of objects of central interest. Kinship, economic matters, and social control—especially where they involve the ownership and inheritance of property and cattle—as well as speech itself, are matters in which direct, precise discourse is called for. However, literal descriptions of cattle and agriculture involve vocabularies of such minutely detailed discriminations as to be quite beyond the capacities of an outsider to master. Barundi are intensely interested in human psychology, and the extensive vocabulary and shrewd generalizations of the ethnopsychology supply linguistic evidence of the cultural concern with motives, emotions, and personality types.

Although the demand for esthetic composition and delivery applies to descriptive discourse, it is at the bottom of a culturally defined series of steps of esthetic complexity. Public address may be placed at the mid-point, and at the top of the esthetic scale, the rich tradition of oral literature. The various types of literary composition have well-defined social and practical functions and communication content often of great significance, but esthetics takes precedence over other values in poetry, in prose (including the narration of historical events), in songs, proverbs, and stylized conversational formula. While criteria for everyday conversation are near the bottom of the scale, elegance of composition and delivery, figures of speech, and the interpolation of stories and proverbs are normally called for and employed.

The Preëminence of Indirect Reference

Praise-poems (*amazina*, literally "names") are composed to honor a generous superior or the author's valor in battle. Highly refined literary-rhetorical skills, composition and delivery of *amazina* are included in the speech training of young boys of good family. The form is fixed but the contents are created impromptu. The naturally alliterative character of Kirundi, a Bantu language, is reinforced by conscious selection of assonant words in the construction of praise-names and figures of speech. There are slight though perceptible modifications in wording and number of verses presented as authors repeat their steadily increasing store of *amazina* on appropriate occasions. Nobody borrows the *amazina* of others, but each must demonstrate his own abilities. For some, virtuosity earns

wide fame. An elderly man with a long history of bravery and gifts of cattle may fill three or four hours with his chanted recitation. The *amazina* in fact are repositories of Rundi history.

The chief requirement for esthetic accomplishment in literature is allusion. The value and delicacy of a composition depends on the remoteness and subtlety of the allusion. Composition of *amazina* is primarily for the upper castes, where in any event the criteria for elegant speech behavior are determined. However, there are also peasant *amazina* of sorts, praise-poems to honor hoes, bees, and other things of interest to them. A prosperous peasant may compose praises for the patron who has given him cattle. Clever cow-thieves, the most dreaded members of the community, may compose *amazina* in self-praise: since the punishment for stealing cattle is immediate crucifixion if the thief is caught in the act and since precautions against stealing are elaborate, a cow thief who lives to tell the tale has earned the right to *amazina*.

A large stock of traditional figures of speech and inventions of new ones are used in *ibicuba* (songs composed by cowherds in praise of their herds), in hunting songs, lullabies, tales, fables, and riddles. Thousands of proverbs, old and new, are in some cases direct, in others more or less subtly allusive. Cultural skill in inventing and interpreting figurative speech and allusions is general, but indirect reference also operates to define boundaries between in-groups and out-groups in various situations. At a princely court, a man may sing a tale full of allusions understood only by the prince himself or only by a few of those present. The incomprehensibility of the allusions is in itself meaningful. Listeners know something is in the wind, and they are not slow to inquire and to find out. If the information were not intended to be made public, it would not have been presented at all; if it were common knowledge, the allusions would not have been incomprehensible. Like the rhetorical technique of strict silence, the poetic technique of not quite telling has positive information content of great significance.

News is carried from one neighborhood to another by individuals on various types of business, but especially by a sort of self-appointed minstrel who sings the news, accompanying himself on a seven-string zither. Great humor, sly and stinging in many cases, is part of the performance, and indirect reference is characteristic. Indirectness of reference through figures of speech is a popular device in polite social intercourse. Gratitude for a gift of beer and cigarettes, both much enjoyed, requires more than a simple word of thanks: "I know a man who named his child *Inzokira*, 'I shall be saved.' For first he received beer and then he received tobacco." Discussing the hardships of life, an old gentleman may remark, "Once I was strong, and now I am weak. Indeed, in the daytime, the sun shines strongly, but at night it is gone. And for me, it is now night."

A request to a superior for a trifling gift, e.g., a new pair of shoes, does not take the form, "I am a poor man, you are rich; please give me money for a new pair of shoes; as you see, these I have are torn to shreds." Rather: "One does not hide one's misfortunes; if one tries to hide them, they will nevertheless soon be revealed. Now, I know a poor old man, broken in health and ill; there is a spear

stuck in his body and he cannot be saved." A terminal gesture directs attention to a pair of ragged tennis shoes, one of the pair held together by means of a "spear," i.e., a safety pin.

In addition to idioms, i.e., locutions that are incomprehensible if taken literally, there are in Rundi discourse a number of stylistic conventions that make statements misleading if taken literally. Speaking of a revolutionary (there was much domestic political disturbance in the 1920's), it is conventional to say, "Nobody knows who he is; nobody knows his family." The speaker knows perfectly well and will go on to tell in great detail the history of the patrilineage in question, its alliances, successes and failures, and ultimate destruction. The conventional introduction is a negative value judgment. If anyone says of a man, "He has no children, there will be nobody to bury him," this must not be taken literally, especially if it is said in the presence of the man's sons. It means that some of his sons have died, i.e., "He fathered many, but many have died." In a somewhat lighter vein, the statement, "I went to X's house but there was no beer," means in fact that only a few quarts were downed, but either the total available supply was small or the number of visitors great, or the reception was not friendly enough, so there was no point in staying on, one's thirst would not be quenched. The name traditionally given to an eleventh or twelfth child is *bujana*, "Hundreds," signifying that the family is a large one. Stylized exaggeration is also common in practical contexts, notably in economic or political negotiations, claims for damages, and in praises—a generous person may be called *mwami*, king, or Imana, God.

To comprehend Rundi communication fully also requires knowledge of conventional gestures, sometimes replaced by statements; e.g., the action or phrase "I pull up grass for you" is a sign of subservience and gratitude. Among the nonlinguistic vocal signals is one that in the United States is the Indian war cry, in Iran the populace's cheer for the shah, but in Burundi, the cry of alarm sent out into the hills to solicit help when animal or human marauders threaten a household.

Fictional Forms for Factual Data: An Illustration

Generally, what men must understand is other men. All else is fit at best for *imigani*, tales, fables and proverbs. The deity is far above man and beyond human comprehension. There are tales of Imana's creation of the universe and of his benevolent dispositions towards men, but it is futile to wonder about his nature or why he created things as he did. The natural environment is a passive instrument of various powers. Storms, lightning, midday sun and heavy rain tend to be unfriendly to man and hence require ritual attention. Otherwise, nature is not important. Techniques and commodities introduced from European culture are warmly welcomed, but they are dead and therefore do not stir intellectual curiosity.

Life is here and now, so the past and future are of little interest. Older men may entertain the younger generation with family history or accounts of wars and political events of the past to which they have been eye-witness. These au-

tomatically become fiction to the listeners, because of the remoteness of the events and the requirement for literary embellishment, especially allusiveness and figures of speech, in the style of narration. A single illustration may suffice to indicate the way in which historical events are likely to be presented: The leader of the Abadagi was a man named Gahezeri Binyori Dagi. He asked Mwongereza for one of his daughters in marriage. This was a trick, for he only wanted to obtain passage through the property of Mwongereza. Once he had married the girl, he asked for permission to hunt elephants. Mwongereza asked him to pay the hunting tax, but Dagi refused. Dagi then went to Mbiligi to ask him for a place on which to settle. While they were talking, Mwongereza appeared. He asked Mbiligi, "What did Dagi say to you?" Mbiligi answered, "He has asked me for a place on which to settle." "Be careful," warned Mwongereza, "he is deceiving you. He wants to take over all your property and then chase you away." After that, Dagi fought with Mwongereza, whom Mbiligi helped. They killed Dagi, and after that Mwongereza and Mbiligi became good friends.

Once a few indirect references and some Africanized eponyms are understood, the tale is a fairly straightforward though condensed account of World War I in Africa. *Dagi* is the Rundi version of *Deutsch* and means "the German." The plural prefix, *aba-*, makes of *Abadagi* "the Germans," who were in control of Burundi prior to World War I. *Mwongereza* is "the English," the word composed of the singular personal prefix *mu-*, modified to *mw-* before a vowel, and *-Ongereza*, the Rundi rendering of "English," allowance made for the interchangeability of "r" and "l." *Mbiligi*, with *mu-* reduced for euphony to *m-*, is "the Belgian." The rest is history. The Germans are represented by Dagi, an eponymous treacherous adventurer; the marriage is a simple symbol of alliance; European interest in the ivory trade is suggested by the reference to elephant hunting; "killing," in the story and in other literary forms is stylized exaggeration for reference to inflicting damage or defeat; the subsequent shift in relations that excluded Germany but made England and Belgium friends is a familiar process in Rundi history also and needed no comment. It is taken for granted that each narrator will invent his own way of telling a story and, if he can, a new way for each telling. Multiple versions of historical events are common, and the same is true in other nonvital types of discourse, e.g., origin tales or descriptions of nature and of natural events.

IMPLICATIONS FOR FIELD WORK

The potential for misunderstanding Burundi verbal behavior is obviously high, and the necessity of examining the uses of language in the context of the social structure, world-view, and value system is proportionally great. Familiar forms and ideas, it should be reiterated, are potentially a threat to reliable perception and reporting. Both value judgments and mechanical problems are involved. In principle, anthropological inquiry is free from invidious comparison with the observer's culture, where it does not bend over backwards to make kindly interpretations. It is no part of the description of a culture pattern to comment on its elements as good or bad or right or wrong. Still, it seems a cour-

tesy due the Burundi from anyone who uses information about their way of life to state what we are all aware of, viz., that the tricks of the rhetorician's trade, altering or concealing truth, hatching plots, and other aspects of speech behavior in Burundi are not less popular in other places, although the "highest ideals" may condemn such practices. It is not improbable that some such sense of obligation to play fair affects the selection and presentation of materials in what is intended as strictly objective reporting.

The more acute problems lie in getting a clear and correct view of the data, in effect in spite of the high cultural evaluation of clever lies and evasions and of elegant but often incomprehensibly subtle literary allusions. Working in Burundi (as in similar cultures in Africa, the Mediterranean, and elsewhere), an anthropologist must learn early (1) not to ask direct questions, except in such matters as asking which of the crossroads leads to Kitega or Astrida; (2) to learn the formula by which individuals signal an intention to use a conversation as a request for a gift; (3) to locate verbal and other cues by which individuals unconsciously indicate either ignorance of the subject on which they are pretending to give information or intentional distortion—e.g., one elderly gentleman, the easiest to deal with, invariably told a whopping lie each time he offered, unasked, his assurance that he did not lie; (4) to seek out and compare alternative accounts of events, since only rarely do different individuals lie about or conceal the same facts; and (5) to learn in detail the patterns of language use and specific meanings—in effect, to play the game of matching wits, albeit against high odds. Rules learned in Burundi are not specifically useful for any other culture. It is, however, probably a good general rule of method that learning the cultural modes of speech behavior is part of procuring reliable data. If consciously adopted, it can save a great deal of time and energy.

That literary form is not a reliable index to the functions of discourse is one of the implications for theory of the examination of Rundi speech behavior. The priority of esthetic and practical values over literal truth and the explicit situational relativism of criteria governing the uses of language and intellect have effects on discourse that indicate the importance of understanding ethno-epistemological principles. Only in cultural context can the content, intention and effects of communication be correctly interpreted.

In comparative perspective, the necessity for culturally specific interpretation of literary form is indicated by scattered data on many cultures. For example, poetry cannot properly be classed as a primarily esthetic phenomenon when, as is so often the case, its main significance is religious. Styles of forensic and political rhetoric vary widely: the demand for oratorical fireworks is strong in Burundi and many other places but is deplored in others, e.g., among Navaho and Zuni Indians or in the present-day United States. Appropriate subjects and situations for literal description as well as the hierarchy of interests in types of knowledge are also culturally variable. Again, literary style can be misleading. That a healer or rain-maker uses ritual formulas and a collection of bones or feathers is not a relevant datum for evaluating the empirical efficacy of the procedures. The same holds when customary technology is explained as a gift of

the gods or of culture heroes. These rationales are not "scientific" in form or content. Trial and error have in every society produced reasonably and sometimes highly reliable empirical sciences. To infer from the literary form that the procedures are so much hocus-pocus is imprecise and contrary to scientific standards. These require conclusions based on reliable evidence, which depends on suitable technical training, laboratory facilities, and observation of the behavioral complexes and actual consequences related to the verbal formulas. This is not to say that all legends are science in disguise but rather to insist that literary form as such is not even a clue to the referential significance of terms and statements.

Multiple versions of the "same" events cannot be interpreted as though the western rationalistic demand for strict consistency and uniform, standard description were universal. Different versions of origin tales or so-called mythopoeic history may well be the product of conscious art and effort, not signs of confusion about facts. Many types of discourse regarded as nonfiction in the West, on religious and secular subjects, are found in multiple versions and literary form in many societies. Before we know with what name to label samples of discourse, we need to know the cultural assumptions about the nature of truth and its range of relevance as well as the prescribed literary forms for communicating different types of subject matter in different situations.

Ethnophilosophy offers only one avenue of approach to the study of culture patterns of speech behavior. Refinement of methods and concepts is obviously needed. Moreover, not until more is known of each of the many aspects of speech behavior can specific linkages among the research results of different specializations be reliably established, e.g., between the lexicon and morphology of a language and the characteristics of the world-view of its speakers, or between the universal features of cognition or learning and the specific patterns of cultures and personalities, or between patterns of speech behavior and related patterns of nonverbal behavior. Since the flow of human speech fills a reservoir of nearly infinite capacity, its students do not lack for materials with which to work.

NOTES

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² "Burundi" is the post-independence form of the name of the kingdom earlier included in the joint designation, Ruanda-Urundi. The Bantu form will be retained for the name of the people, viz., Barundi (singular, Murundi); "Kirundi" for the language; but for the adjective, only the stem will be used, viz., Rundi.